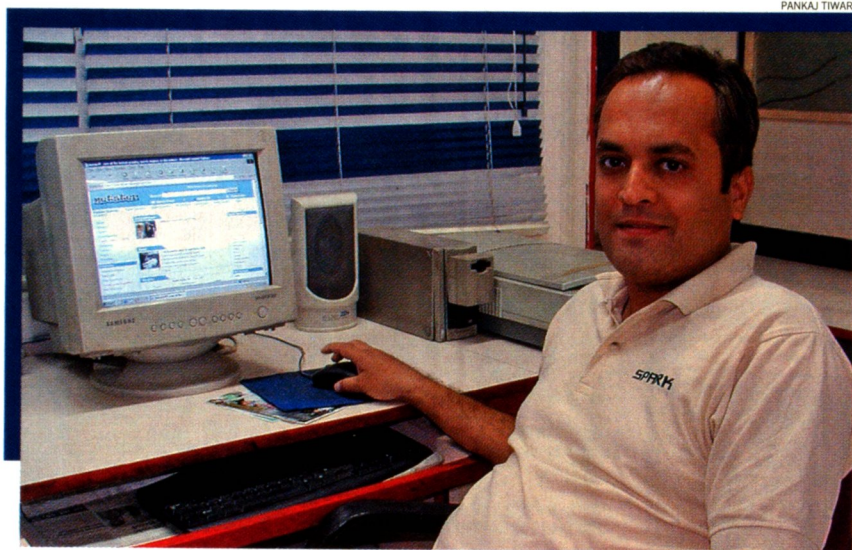


All it took was a newspaper ad and Ahuja was hooked. Six years on, he can't imagine life without logging into his e-broker site. "The paperwork is totally cut out, I save time because it's real-time transactions and it's all so easy."

MANOJ AHUJA, 36, Media professional, INDORE



PANKAJ TIWARI

corporate executive, has not visited his bank branch for over three years. But at the same time he believes that the onus of security lies as much with the customer as with the bank. "The best security measures are those taken at an individual level. After all nobody can promise insurance against stupidity," says Khan, who retired as the vice-president of corporate communications, Coca-Cola India.

THE ROAD AHEAD

Standard Chartered Bank's Gupta claims that traditional banking is eight times more expensive than online banking, and mobile banking. Therefore, newer banks are promoting hi-tech banking to reduce their costs. Public sector banks, traditionally slow in adopting new technology, too are in sync with the time. Says Jagmandir Singh, a branch manager with State Bank of India (SBI), "Today there is no business left for which you will have to come to the branch. About 60 per cent of our customers in urban areas prefer to bank from home." But these banks also have a customer profile that will take time to adapt to new technology. Naresh Goel, a senior official of Syndicate Bank, explains, "The 40-plus age group in the country holds the purse strings and they aren't tech savvy, or even early adopters of new systems." Moreover, the staff of many PSU banks also tends to resist changes.

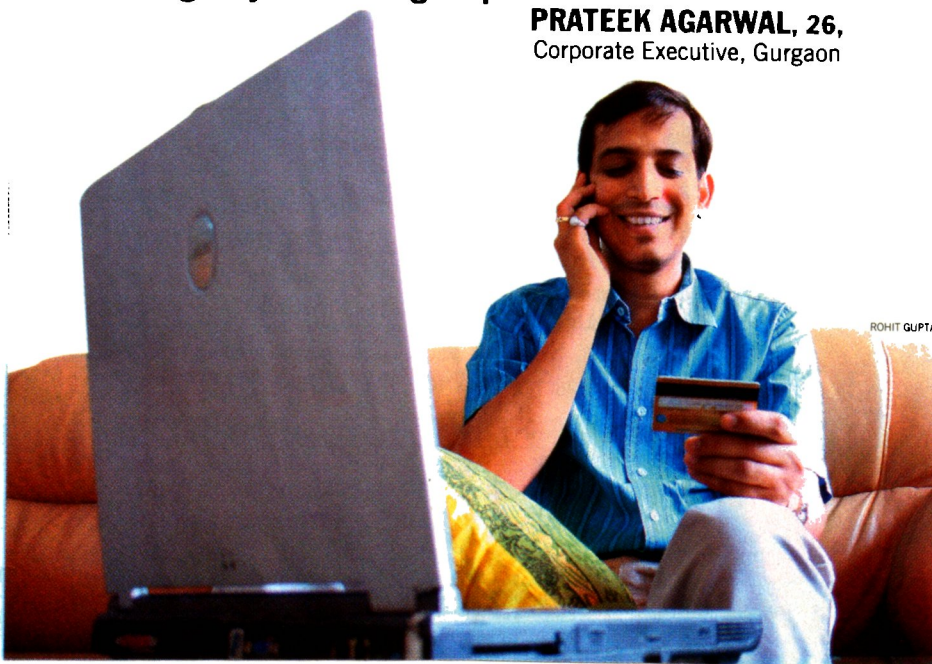
However, these are temporary glitches. The pull and push factor of branchless banking is too compelling for it not to become popular. Only, most bankers believe that e-banking's evolution will not completely replace the bank branch. Even now most customers wish to maintain a traditional banking relationship so banks can't shed existing infrastructure in a hurry.

Ultimately, e-banking spells more self-reliance and less hand-holding. But then again, we all have to grow up some day.

with Sudhir Gore

An assistant manager with Bharti Airtel, Agarwal has been doing mobile banking for the past one year, but he joined the Net banking bandwagon much earlier. "While I make all kinds of transactions online, I use mobile banking only for making enquiries."

PRATEEK AGARWAL, 26, Corporate Executive, Gurgaon



ROHIT GUPTA